THE LAYOFF COMEBACK INTERVIEW KIT

Laid Off? Get Hired Again.

Word-for-word interview scripts for people who lost their job — so you can answer **“Why did you leave?”**, explain your **employment gap**, and handle every tough question **confident instead of defensive.**

- ✓ The 3-Part Layoff Answer Formula
- ✓ Employment-gap scripts by length
- ✓ 14 tough follow-up questions
- ✓ 15 questions to ask the interviewer
- ✓ 12 layoff & exit scripts
- ✓ “Tell me about yourself” builder
- ✓ Story Bank worksheets (STAR)
- ✓ Thank-you & follow-up email templates

PRINTABLE & FILLABLE WORKBOOK · 48-HOUR PREP PLAN INCLUDED

START HERE

You lost a job. Not your value.

Being laid off is one of the most common things that happens in a career — and one of the least practiced things to talk about. This kit fixes the second part.

Most laid-off candidates don't lose offers because of the layoff. They lose offers because of **how they talk about it**: too long, too emotional, too apologetic, or too vague. Interviewers notice the hesitation more than the facts.

This workbook gives you short, honest, ready-to-adapt answers for the questions you're dreading, plus worksheets to turn your own experience into proof that you're the right hire.

How to use this kit

1. **Interview in 2+ days?** Follow the 48-Hour Plan on the next page, top to bottom.
2. **Interview tomorrow?** Do only: Layoff Formula (p. 4), your exit script (p. 5–6), "Tell me about yourself" (p. 9), Questions to Ask (p. 15), Day-Of Checklist (p. 17).
3. **Still job searching?** Fill in the Story Bank (p. 13–14) once. You'll reuse it in every interview.

THE GOLDEN RULE OF THIS KIT

Adapt every script to your own words and your real situation. Never claim something that isn't true — a confident, honest answer always beats a polished lie that falls apart on a follow-up question.

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YOUR PLAN

The 48-Hour Interview Plan

Tick each box as you go. Total active time: about 5–6 hours, split over two days.

Day 1 — Get your story straight (about 3 hours)

- [ ] Read the Layoff Answer Formula (p. 4) and pick the exit script that matches your situation (p. 5–6).
- [ ] Rewrite that script in your own words on the worksheet. Time it out loud: **under 30 seconds**.
- [ ] If you have a gap of 2+ months, write your gap answer (p. 7–8).
- [ ] Build your “Tell me about yourself” answer (p. 9). Target: 60–90 seconds.
- [ ] Fill in at least 4 stories in your Story Bank (p. 13–14).
- [ ] Research the company: website, recent news, the job ad. Write down 3 problems this role is meant to solve.

Day 2 — Practice and prepare (about 2–3 hours)

- [ ] Read the 14 Tough Follow-Up Questions (p. 10–12). Mark the 5 you fear most and draft answers.
- [ ] Record yourself on your phone answering: exit question, gap, tell me about yourself, two stories. Listen back once.
- [ ] Cut every answer that runs longer than 2 minutes.
- [ ] Choose 3 questions to ask the interviewer (p. 15).
- [ ] Complete the Day-Of Checklist (p. 17) the evening before.
- [ ] Prepare your thank-you email draft (p. 18) so you can send it the same day.

WHY PRACTICING OUT LOUD MATTERS

An answer that looks good on paper can sound stiff or run long when spoken. Saying it out loud 3–5 times is what makes it sound natural instead of memorized.

THE CORE METHOD

The 3-Part Layoff Answer Formula

When an interviewer asks why you left, they are not asking for your life story. They are checking three things: *Is this candidate honest? Was it a performance problem? Will they be bitter or focused?*

1. Fact
One short, neutral sentence about what happened. No drama, no blame.

2. Context
One sentence showing it wasn't about your performance — or what you learned.

3. Forward
Pivot to why you want *this* role. End on the future, not the past.

Total length: **15–30 seconds.** Then stop talking. Silence after a good answer is fine — it signals you're comfortable with your story.

Example

STRONG ANSWER

"My role was one of about 200 positions eliminated when the company restructured its sales division in March. ***[Fact]*** *I'd exceeded my targets two quarters in a row, so it was a business decision rather than a performance one.* ***[Context]*** *It actually gave me the chance to be selective, and this role stood out because it combines account management with the analytics work I enjoyed most.* ***[Forward]****"*

WEAK ANSWER — AVOID

"Honestly it was really unfair. Management had no idea what they were doing, they kept changing direction, and then one day they just let a bunch of us go with no warning. I'm still not sure why I was picked..."

Why it hurts: it's long, emotional, blames others, and ends on uncertainty. The interviewer now wonders what you'll say about *them* one day.

The four rules

1. **Lead with the fact.** Hesitating or "softening" before you say it makes it sound worse than it is.
2. **Never criticize your former employer** — even if they deserve it.
3. **Use proof, not reassurance.** "I exceeded targets" beats "I was a good employee."
4. **Always end forward.** Your last sentence should be about this job.

SCRIPTS

“Why did you leave your last job?”

Find the situation closest to yours. Replace everything in [brackets]. Keep the structure.

1. Company-wide layoff

“I was part of a company-wide reduction of [number / about X%] of staff in [month]. Entire teams were affected, including mine. I'm proud of what I delivered there — [one result]. Now I'm looking for a role where I can [what you want to do], which is exactly why this position caught my attention.”

2. Your position was eliminated

“The company decided to stop investing in [product/area], and my position was eliminated as part of that change. Before that, I [key achievement]. I'm looking to bring that same experience to a team that's growing in [area] — like yours.”

3. Restructuring after a merger or acquisition

“After [Company] was acquired by [Company], the two teams were merged and several roles, including mine, became duplicates. I stayed on to [hand over / complete project], which I was glad to do. Now I'm ready for [what's next].”

4. Department closed or relocated

“The [department] was moved to [location / outsourced], and the local team was let go. Relocating wasn't an option for me at the time, so I'm focused on finding a role like this one, where I can [contribution].”

5. Startup ran out of funding

“The startup wasn't able to close its next funding round and had to cut most of the team. Working there taught me to [skill — e.g. move fast, wear many hats]. I'm now looking for a more stable environment where I can apply that, and [this company] fits.”

6. Contract or temporary role ended

“It was a [length] contract to [goal], and we completed it [on time / with result]. I'm now looking for a permanent role where I can build on that over the long term.”

SCRIPTS — HARDER SITUATIONS

When it's more complicated

These situations need extra care. Be honest — but you control the emphasis.

7. You were let go and only some people were affected

They may wonder: why you and not others?

"The team was reduced from [X] to [Y] people. Decisions were based on [seniority / which projects continued / budget per role]. I understand the business reasoning, and I left on good terms — my manager is one of my references. Since then I've [course / project / sharpened skill]."

8. You were fired for performance

Don't call this a layoff — if they check, you lose all trust. Own it briefly, show the lesson.

"The role wasn't the right fit. It needed [skill] at a level I didn't have yet, and after [time] we agreed to part ways. I took it seriously: I've since [specific action — course, practice, project], and this role plays much more to my strengths in [strength]."

9. You quit without having a new job lined up

"I decided to leave to [reason — e.g. focus fully on finding a role that matches my long-term direction / handle a family matter]. It was a deliberate choice, and it's given me the time to be selective. This role is one of the few I've applied for, because [reason]."

10. You left because of burnout or health

You don't owe details about your health.

"I took some time off to deal with a personal matter that's now fully resolved. I'm rested, ready, and very focused on getting back to [work you do]."

11. You were laid off more than once

"I've worked in [industry], which has been hit by several rounds of cuts — both of my last two employers reduced staff. Across both roles I [consistent result]. That's partly why I'm drawn to [this company]: [stability signal — growth, funding, long history]."

12. You're still employed but have been told your role is ending

"My role is being phased out on [date] as part of a restructuring. I'm finishing [handover / project] and starting my search early so I can make a thoughtful move rather than a rushed one."

YOUR VERSION — WRITE IT, THEN TIME IT (GOAL: UNDER 30 SECONDS)

EMPLOYMENT GAP

Explaining the gap in your résumé

A gap is only a problem if you look uncomfortable about it. Interviewers mainly want to know two things: *Were you doing something? Are you ready now?*

Gap length	What interviewers usually think	How much to say
Under 3 months	Normal job search. Often not even asked.	One sentence, only if asked.
3–6 months	Normal in a tough market. They'll want a brief explanation.	Fact + one thing you did.
6–12 months	They want to see you kept your skills current.	Fact + activity + proof you're ready.
12+ months	They want reassurance you're committed and up to date.	Address it proactively, with concrete activities.

The Gap Formula

1. Reason
Why the gap exists, in one sentence.

2. Activity
What you did that's useful: learning, freelance, volunteering, caregiving.

3. Ready
Why you're fully ready now and why this role.

Activities that count (and how to phrase them)

- **Courses or certificates:** “I completed [course] to strengthen my [skill].”
- **Freelance or side projects:** “I did [number] freelance projects in [area], for example [result].”
- **Volunteering:** “I helped [organization] with [task], which kept my [skill] sharp.”
- **Caregiving:** “I was caring for a family member. That's now settled, and I'm fully available.”
- **A focused job search:** “I've been selective — I wanted my next move to be the right one, not just the next one.”

TIP

If you have nothing to show for the gap yet, start one small thing **today** — a free online course, a portfolio piece, helping a friend's business. “I'm currently doing X” is a real, honest answer.

EMPLOYMENT GAP — SCRIPTS

Gap scripts you can adapt

3–6 month gap after a layoff

"After the layoff in [month], I took a few weeks to reset and then started a focused search. I've also used the time to [course / project]. I've been selective because I want my next role to be a long-term fit — and this one is."

6–12 month gap

"The market in [industry] has been slow, so I've used this time deliberately. I completed [certification], and I've done [freelance / volunteer work] for [who], where I [result]. So my skills are current and I'm ready to commit fully to a team again."

12+ month gap

"You may notice I've been out of a full-time role since [year]. I [reason — e.g. was caring for my father / dealt with a health matter that's fully resolved / took a planned break after a layoff]. During that time I kept up with [field] by [activities]. I'm now fully available and genuinely excited to get back to [work] — this role is a great match because [reason]."

Gap while switching careers

"After my role in [old field] ended, I decided to move into [new field] rather than go back to the same thing. I spent the time [training / projects] — for example [concrete project]. I bring [transferable skill] from [old field], which I think is an advantage in this role."

Write your gap answer

1. REASON

2. ACTIVITY (WHAT YOU DID / ARE DOING)

3. READY (WHY NOW, WHY THIS ROLE)

SPOKEN TIME

THE OPENING QUESTION

“Tell me about yourself”

This question sets the tone for the whole interview. For laid-off candidates, the trap is starting with the layoff. Don't. Lead with your strengths — the layoff is one sentence near the end, if at all.

Present
Who you are professionally, in one line + your strongest skill.

Past
1–2 achievements that prove it, with numbers if possible.

Future
Why this role is your next step.

Length: **60–90 seconds.** Leave out: your childhood, your entire CV, personal problems, and anything you can't connect to this job.

EXAMPLE

“I'm a customer success manager with six years in B2B software, and what I'm best at is turning unhappy accounts into long-term ones. At my last company I managed 40 mid-size accounts and brought churn down from 14% to 8% in a year, mostly by setting up quarterly business reviews nobody had done before. That role ended when the company cut its European team in June. I'm now looking for a growing company where retention is a priority — and from what I've read about your expansion plans, that's exactly the challenge here.”

Build yours

PRESENT — I'M A [ROLE] WITH [X YEARS] IN [FIELD], AND WHAT I'M BEST AT IS...

PAST — ACHIEVEMENT 1 (WITH A NUMBER)

PAST — ACHIEVEMENT 2 (OPTIONAL)

BRIDGE — ONE NEUTRAL SENTENCE ABOUT WHY YOU'RE AVAILABLE (OPTIONAL)

FUTURE — WHY THIS ROLE / COMPANY

TOUGH FOLLOW-UPS

14 questions laid-off candidates dread

For each: what they're really asking, what to avoid, and a script to adapt.

1. “Why were you chosen and not others?”

Really asking: was it performance? Avoid: guessing, sounding bitter.

“The cuts were based on [criteria — e.g. which projects continued]. My project was one of those discontinued. My last review was [positive / rating], and my manager is happy to speak to that.”

2. “Were you a low performer?”

Really asking: are you a risk? Avoid: getting defensive.

“No — and I'm happy for you to check. In my last year I [result with number]. The decision was about [budget / direction], not individual performance.”

3. “How do you feel about your former employer?”

Really asking: will you be negative? Avoid: any complaint at all.

“Grateful, honestly. I learned a lot there, especially [skill]. Layoffs are never fun, but I understand why the company made the decision.”

4. “What have you been doing since you left?”

Really asking: are you active and up to date?

“Three things: a focused job search, [course / certification], and [project / freelance / volunteering]. The [course] in particular helped me get up to speed with [tool or trend relevant to this job].”

5. “Why do you want this job?” (and not just any job)

Really asking: are you desperate or genuinely interested?

“I've been selective in my search. This role stood out because [specific thing from job ad], and it's where my experience in [X] would make an immediate difference — for example, [how you'd help].”

TOUGH FOLLOW-UPS

Continued

6. “Why should we hire you?”

Really asking: what's the business case for you?

“You need someone who can [top requirement from the ad]. I've done exactly that — [proof]. I can also bring [second strength], which [helps their goal]. And because I'm available now, I can start contributing quickly.”

7. “What are your salary expectations?”

Avoid: naming a low number out of fear. Research the range first.

“Based on my research for this role in [location], I'm looking at a range of [range]. I'm flexible depending on the full package and the growth potential here.”

8. “Aren't you overqualified for this role?”

Really asking: will you leave as soon as something better comes?

“I see it as a strong match rather than a step down. What matters most to me now is [reason — stability, the product, the team, the field], and I'd rather go deep in a role I enjoy than chase a title.”

9. “Do you have other interviews or offers?”

“I'm in conversations with a few companies, but this role is my first choice because [reason].”

Only say this if it's true. If not: “I've been selective and this is one of the few roles I've applied for.”

10. “Why are you changing careers?”

“The layoff made me step back and think about where I do my best work. It's [new field] — I've already [course / project] and I bring [transferable skill] that most candidates coming straight into this field don't have.”

TOUGH FOLLOW-UPS

Continued

11. “Tell me about a time you failed.”

Avoid: using the layoff as your failure, or a fake failure (“I work too hard”).

“On [project], I [mistake — e.g. underestimated how long the data migration would take]. We missed the first deadline by [time]. I told my manager early, re-planned with the team, and we delivered [result]. Since then I always [lesson in practice].”

12. “Tell me about a conflict with a colleague or manager.”

“A colleague and I disagreed about [topic]. Instead of escalating, I asked for a 20-minute meeting to understand their reasons. It turned out [insight]. We agreed on [solution], and the result was [result]. We worked well together after that.”

13. “What's your greatest weakness?”

“I used to [real, non-critical weakness — e.g. take on too many tasks myself instead of delegating]. On my last project that slowed us down, so I started [concrete fix]. It's not perfect yet, but [evidence of improvement].”

14. “Where do you see yourself in five years?”

Really asking: will you stay?

“Growing within a company like this one — deeper expertise in [area], and ideally taking on more responsibility like [mentoring / leading projects]. After the last year, I'm looking for a place to build something long-term.”

YOUR 5 MOST-FEARED QUESTIONS

Write them below and draft an answer for each in your notes. Practice these first.

STORY BANK

Your Story Bank

Most behavioral questions (“Tell me about a time when...”) can be answered with the same 6–8 stories. Write them once, reuse them in every interview.

STAR: Situation (where/when) · **T**ask (your responsibility) · **A**ction (what *you* did — the biggest part) · **R**esult (number or concrete outcome). Spoken length: about 90 seconds.

Story 1 — A big achievement

Use for: proudest moment, why hire you, biggest impact

S / T

A

R

Story 2 — A problem you solved under pressure

Use for: stress, deadlines, difficult situations

S / T

A

R

Story 3 — A conflict or disagreement

Use for: teamwork, difficult colleague, disagreeing with a manager

S / T

A

R

STORY BANK

Continued

Story 4 — A mistake or failure

Use for: failure, weakness, what you learned

S / T

A

R + LESSON

Story 5 — Adapting to change

Use for: change, uncertainty, restructuring — great for laid-off candidates

S / T

A

R

Story 6 — Leading or taking initiative

Use for: leadership, initiative, going beyond your role

S / T

A

R

Story 7 — Helping a customer or colleague

Use for: customer focus, going the extra mile, collaboration

S / T

A

R

END OF THE INTERVIEW

15 questions to ask the interviewer

“Do you have any questions for us?” is not a formality. Good questions show you're evaluating them too — the opposite of desperate. Pick 2–3.

About the role

1. What would success look like in this role after the first 90 days?
2. What's the biggest challenge the person in this role will face?
3. Why is this position open — is it new or a replacement?
4. What does a typical week look like?

About the team

5. How would you describe the team I'd be working with?
6. How does the team handle disagreements or changes in direction?
7. What do people who do well here have in common?

About the company (smart for laid-off candidates)

8. What are the company's main priorities for the next year?
9. How has the team changed over the past year?
10. How is this role connected to the company's growth plans?

About growth

11. How do you support learning and development?
12. Where have people in this role moved on to within the company?

Closing questions

13. Is there anything about my background that makes you hesitate? I'd like the chance to address it.
14. What are the next steps in the process?
15. When can I expect to hear from you?

AVOID IN A FIRST INTERVIEW

Questions only about salary, vacation days or remote days; questions you could answer from their website; “No, I don't have any questions.”

LANGUAGE

Words that hurt you / words that help you

Small word choices change how a layoff sounds. Swap the left column for the right.

Instead of...	Say...
“I got fired” (when it was a layoff)	“My role was eliminated” / “I was part of a layoff”
“Unfortunately...” / “I'm sorry, but...”	Just state the fact — no apology needed
“They let me go for no reason”	“It was a business decision related to [budget / direction]”
“Management was terrible”	“The company changed direction”
“I'll take anything”	“I've been selective — this role stood out because...”
“I've just been sitting at home”	“I've been focused on my search and on [course/project]”
“I'm not sure why they picked me”	“Decisions were based on [criteria]”
“I really need this job”	“I'm very interested in this role”
“I was just doing my job”	“I [verb + result + number]”
“I think maybe I could...”	“I would...” / “I can...”

Strong action verbs for your answers

- Increased / reduced
- Launched / built
- Led / coordinated
- Solved / fixed
- Improved / streamlined
- Negotiated / closed
- Trained / mentored
- Delivered / achieved

NUMBERS MAKE YOU CREDIBLE

Every story is stronger with a number: %, €/$, time saved, customers, team size, deadlines. If you don't know the exact figure, a careful estimate (“roughly 20%”) is fine — as long as it's honest.

CHECKLISTS

Day-before, day-of & video interview

The evening before

- [ ] Re-read the job ad and your notes on the company
- [ ] Say your exit answer out loud 3 times
- [ ] Say “Tell me about yourself” out loud twice
- [ ] Pick your 3 questions to ask
- [ ] Prepare outfit (one level more formal than their dress code)
- [ ] Print or save your CV and the job ad
- [ ] Check route / travel time + 15 minutes extra
- [ ] Name and role of the interviewer(s) written down
- [ ] Sleep — no all-night cramming

On the day

- [ ] Eat something light
- [ ] Arrive 10 minutes early (not 30)
- [ ] Phone on silent
- [ ] Notebook + pen with your 3 questions
- [ ] Smile, firm greeting, use their name

Video interview

- [ ] Test the link, camera and microphone 30 minutes before
- [ ] Camera at eye level (stack books under your laptop)
- [ ] Light in front of you, not behind you
- [ ] Plain, tidy background
- [ ] Close all other apps and notifications
- [ ] Phone hotspot ready as backup internet
- [ ] Look at the camera when you speak, not at yourself
- [ ] Notes on a sticky note next to the camera (key points only)
- [ ] Headphones with a microphone if your room echoes

One-way recorded interviews

- [ ] Use the practice question if offered
- [ ] Keep answers 60–90 seconds; STAR still works
- [ ] Start with a short smile — it's a recording, but a person watches it

AFTER THE INTERVIEW

Email templates

1. Thank-you email (send within 24 hours)

Subject: Thank you — [Job Title] interview

Hi [Name],

Thank you for taking the time to speak with me today about the [Job Title] role. I especially enjoyed hearing about [specific topic from the interview].

Our conversation confirmed my interest. I'm confident my experience with [relevant skill/result] would help the team with [their challenge].

Please let me know if you need anything else from me. I look forward to hearing about the next steps.

Best regards,
[Your name]
[Phone]

2. Follow-up (if you haven't heard back after the date they gave you)

Subject: Following up — [Job Title]

Hi [Name],

I hope you're well. I wanted to follow up on my interview on [date] for the [Job Title] position. I'm still very interested in the role and would be glad to provide any additional information.

Is there an update on the timeline?

Kind regards,
[Your name]

3. After a rejection (keeps the door open)

Subject: Re: [Job Title]

Hi [Name],

Thank you for letting me know, and for the time you and the team spent with me. I enjoyed learning about [company] and would be glad to be considered for future openings.

If you have a moment, I'd really appreciate any feedback that could help me in my search.

All the best,
[Your name]

FINAL WORDS

One interview at a time.

Every interview — even one that doesn't lead to an offer — makes the next one easier. Your stories get sharper, your exit answer gets shorter, and your nerves get quieter.

After each interview, take 5 minutes

Company / date	Question that surprised me	What I'll improve

REMEMBER

The layoff is one sentence in your story. Your skills, your results and your next chapter are the rest of it. Say the sentence calmly — then talk about everything else.

This guide offers general interview preparation tips and example answers; it is not legal, financial or career-counselling advice, and results depend on your situation and the employer. Adapt every script so it is truthful for you. This product was created with the help of AI writing tools and was reviewed and edited by the author.

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